The First Two Weeks

For the first fourteen days after your mother or father dies. Nothing here has to be done perfectly, or all at once. Tick what's done and skip what doesn't apply. If someone offers to help, give them a line from this page.

The first day

- [ ] If your parent was in hospice, call the hospice first. If you are not sure they have died, call 911.
- [ ] If they registered as a brain donor, tell the contact within two hours.
- [ ] Call one person to be with you, in the room or on the phone.
- [ ] If your other parent lived with them, make sure someone stays tonight.
- [ ] Start one notebook, and write down every call.

The next few days

- [ ] Choose a funeral home. You can ask prices by phone without giving your name.
- [ ] Give the funeral home your parent's Social Security number, so it can report the death.
- [ ] Look for written funeral wishes, a prepaid plan and, if they served, the DD214 discharge papers.
- [ ] Feed any pets. Lock the house. Check the heat and water.
- [ ] Ask one person to answer the phone and tell the rest of the family.

This week

- [ ] At the funeral home, ask for the General Price List first. You can choose only the items you want.
- [ ] Count the places that will want a certified death certificate, then order that many.
- [ ] If your parent served in the military, ask about VA burial benefits.
- [ ] Check that Social Security has been told. If not, call **1-800-772-1213**.
- [ ] If a Social Security payment arrives after the death, leave it in the account and tell the bank.
- [ ] Tell your employer, and ask human resources what leave you have.

By the end of week two

- [ ] Ask your parent's lawyer, and the probate court where they lived, whether there is a will.
- [ ] Search for life insurance with the NAIC Life Insurance Policy Locator.
- [ ] Collect the mail by hand. Forwarding it to you needs proof that you are the executor or administrator.
- [ ] Cut advertising mail by registering your parent at DMAchoice.org.
- [ ] Keep every paper in one box: bills, letters, receipts.

WHAT CAN WAIT

- The house, and everything in it.
- Closing accounts and utilities.
- The final tax return. It is due when your parent's return would have been.
- Thank-you notes.
- Anyone who wants money today. Hang up and call back on a number you trust.

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General information for readers in the United States. It is not legal, financial, tax or medical advice. Phone numbers checked October 2026.

Your numbers, in one place

Write the numbers in as you find them. Three are printed for you.

The funeral home	
The hospice or your parent's doctor	
Social Security	1-800-772-1213 (TTY 1-800-325-0778)
VA benefits, if your parent served	1-800-827-1000
The probate court where your parent lived	
Your parent's lawyer, if there is one	
Your employer or human resources	
The person helping you	
If today is very bad	Call or text 988, or chat at chat.988lifeline.org

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline: call or text 988, or chat at chat.988lifeline.org. Free, confidential, any hour of any day. It is also for people worried about a friend or loved one.

Crisis Text Line: text HOME to 741741 from anywhere in the United States, any hour.

Veterans Crisis Line: dial 988 then press 1, text 838255, or chat at veteranscrisisline.net. For veterans and service members, and for their families and friends.

Every call, written down

Every office asks the same questions. A line for each call saves you from starting over.

DATE	WHO	NUMBER	REF. NO.	WHAT THEY NEED	DONE

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